Andhra Pradesh maintains that the Central Water Commission (CWC) made a thorough assessment of flood level flows before deciding upon 45.72 metres as the Polavaram project's Full Reservoir Level (FRL). Andhra Pradesh water resources minister Ambati Rambabu points out that after the FRL was fixed, villages facing a threat of submergence were merged, and preventive measures are being taken by the state government. "There is also no truth in the charge that Andhra was raising the height by three metres. Were there no floods before causing inundation in Bhadrachalam?" asks Rambabu.

Telangana has repeatedly requested the Centre to address the perceived threat. It demanded a fresh environmental impact assessment and filed an affidavit in the Supreme Court in 2017. Another issue raised was that Andhra had had the project redesigned to enable it to hold 5 million cusecs of water, as against the initial capacity of 3.5 million cusecs. But the Centre has not responded to these issues, says Rajat Kumar, Telangana's special chief secretary, water resources.

The project was in a limbo after Andhra Pradesh CM T. Anjaiah laid its foundation in 1980. When the Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy government assumed office in 2004, Polavaram became a priority project, only to be put on the backburner after his death in 2009. In 2014, the UPA government declared Polavaram a designated national project, as an incentive to compensate the residuary Andhra Pradesh for its capital Hyderabad going to Telangana.

On July 19, Bishweswar Tudu, the Union minister of state for Jal Shakti, cited low spending capacity, inadequate construction management, lack of planning and the Covid pandemic as reasons for the delay in project's completion. The delayed land acquisition and rehabilitation process accounts for Rs 33,000 crore of the Rs 58,000 crore total expenditure. The April 2022 deadline is now revised to June 2024. However, the thickening of the quarrel can only slow down the project. ■

JHARKHAND

Cash and Carry Operations

By Amitabh Srivastava



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

STACKED West Bengal police with the three arrested MLAs; (inset) the seized cash

On July 27, West Bengal police intercepted a Toyota SUV carrying three MLAs from Jharkhand and recovered Rs 49.37 lakh in cash from the vehicle at Howrah. Congress MLAs Irfan Ansari, Rajesh Kachchap and Naman Bixal Kongari were subsequently arrested as they couldn't come up with a plausible explanation for why they were carrying so much money.

As expected, the arrests triggered political tremors in Jharkhand where the Congress and Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) are alliance partners with the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) in the Hemant Soren-led government. Jharkhand is one of only three heartland states—Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan being the other two—where the Congress is still in power.

Already under pressure after the collapse of the Uddhav Thackeray-led Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi alliance government in Maharashtra and cross-voting by its Jharkhand MLAs in the recently held presidential polls, the Congress leadership acted quickly, suspending the three errant MLAs. Party leaders also blame it on a "botched Operation Lotus", a euphemism for the poaching of Congress MLAs by the BJP in several states. Kumar Jaimangal Singh, party MLA from Bermo, also filed an FIR in

The Congress says the seizures only showed a "botched Operation Lotus plan" to topple the Soren regime

Ranchi, alleging that his arrested colleagues had offered him crores and a ministerial berth to bring down the state government. Babulal Marandi, BJP leader in the assembly, rubbished the allegations, though, and said the Congress should stop trying to malign